

FAITHFUL PATH

The Christian Spiritual Reset

A guided retreat to overcome burnout, hear God clearly, and renew your faith

Retreat Session Guide

The ten sessions, complete: teaching, guided prayer, silence, journaling questions, and exercise instructions. Take this, the Workbook, and your Bible.

Richmond Kobe · faithfulpathcommunity.com

If a session brings up more than you can hold

Stop the session. Not necessarily the retreat; the session.

- ☐ Open your eyes. Stand up and move. Go outside if it is safe.
- ☐ Drink some water. Look around and name where you are, what day it is, and several things you can see and hear.
- ☐ Remind yourself: I am here, in the present.
- ☐ Pray simply, even if the only prayer you have is "Lord, help."
- ☐ Contact your support person (their number is on your Emergency Information Card).
- ☐ If you are in danger, cannot remain safe, or need urgent medical attention, contact emergency services now.

You do not have to finish the exercise that brought it up. The sessions are offered, not assigned. A retreat that is paused has not failed.

The silence is always adjustable

You may shorten it, keep your eyes open, walk slowly instead of sitting, add neutral background sound, or stop. Choose the length before you begin and treat it as a plan, not a contract. Use the anchor phrase given in each session: when your attention wanders, say it once, slowly, and let it go again.

Three forms of silence: still (sitting with the phrase), moving (slow walking, no digital input), supported (eyes open, neutral sound, a trusted person nearby). None is more spiritual than the others.

Nothing you sense on the retreat is acted on during the retreat. Write it down. It will be tested afterwards, against Scripture, with wise people, and with time. Unless immediate safety requires action, make no irreversible decision here.

Scripture quotations are from the ESV® Bible (The Holy Bible, English Standard Version®), © 2001 by Crossway, a publishing ministry of Good News Publishers. Used by permission. All rights reserved.

Day 1: Arrive and Become Present

This is what Richmond says in the day's introduction video. Read it before the first session of the day.

You've arrived.

Before we do anything else, take care of the ordinary things. Unpack. Find the chair or corner where you will sit. Put your phone where you agreed to put it. Make a drink.

If you are tired—and you probably are—give yourself permission to do nothing for a while before beginning. Rest for an hour if you need it. There is no prize for starting quickly.

Day 1 contains two sessions, and they are the gentlest sessions of the retreat. They will not deliberately take you into the deeper work of grief, confession, or forgiveness. But feelings may still surface when you become quiet. If they do, you do not have to analyse or resolve them today.

Today is about arriving.

Your first session is called "Come As You Are."

We will read the story Jesus told about a son who came home with a speech prepared—a plan for making himself acceptable to his father.

Many of us arrive at a retreat in the same way. We intend to be disciplined enough, repentant enough, or spiritual enough that, by the end of three days, we will have earned the right to be received.

But the story says something much simpler.

While the son was still a long way off, his father saw him and ran to him. The welcome did not depend on the speech.

It will not depend on yours either.

At the end of the session, you will write some of your ordinary, non-urgent demands on cards and seal them in an envelope. You will reopen it on Day 3.

Do not put a safety concern, medical need, crisis, or urgent caregiving responsibility into that envelope. Those matters should receive appropriate attention now.

After the envelope is sealed, your mind may return to it. That is normal. Notice the thought without judging yourself, and gently leave the envelope closed.

This afternoon—after a meal, some rest, a walk, or perhaps a sleep—you will begin the second session: "Be Still and Become Present."

You will sit with Psalm 46 and enter a slightly longer period of silence. The suggested time is fifteen minutes, but if ten minutes was your limit this morning, stay with ten. Five attentive minutes is also a real beginning.

Silence here is not emptiness. It is attention. You will be given a line of Scripture or a short prayer phrase to hold, so you will not be left without direction.

Remember two things.

First, everything today is offered, not assigned. If anything brings up more than you can safely hold, stop. Open your eyes, stand up, go outside if it is safe, and use what you learned in Lesson 5.

Second, you are not doing this alone. Someone knows where you are, and God has seen you coming for a long time.

Place the pages you prepared beside your Bible. Choose the audio timer or set your own timer within reach.

There is no need to hurry.

When you are ready, begin.

Come As You Are

Before you begin

You have arrived. Before anything else, do the ordinary things: unpack, find where you will sit, put the phone where you agreed to put it, and make a drink. If you are tired, and Lesson 6 said you might be, allow yourself an hour to do nothing before you start. There is no prize for beginning quickly.

When you are ready, take out the pages you wrote before you came: the check-in from Lesson 4, the intention from Lesson 7, and any notes on resistance from Lesson 8. Put them beside your Bible. Set your timer within reach. Then read on.

Central passage

Luke 15:11–24

Read the passage twice, slowly. The second time, pay attention to verse 20.

Teaching

Jesus told this parable in response to people who complained that he welcomed sinners and ate with them (Luke 15:1–2). It is the third of three stories in Luke 15 about something lost and found, and it ends with an elder brother who resents the welcome. We will not deal with him today. But it is worth knowing that the running father is not only private comfort; he is Jesus' picture of God's joy in receiving the lost, told to people who thought such joy was a scandal.

Most people arrive at a retreat the way the younger son arrives home: with a speech prepared.

In the far country, after reaching the end of himself, he formed the speech he intended to give his father. "Father, I have sinned against heaven and before you. I am no longer worthy to be called your son. Treat me as one of your hired servants." Parts of the speech are deeply honest: he has sinned, and he is no longer worthy to claim his former place. But it also contains a plan for managing his return by negotiating a new position in the household. He proposes coming back not as a son who must be received, but as a worker who can earn a place. He appears more able to imagine employment than restored relationship.

When the son finally speaks, he confesses his sin and unworthiness, but the proposed line about becoming a hired servant is never recorded. Verse 20 says that "while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and felt compassion, and ran and embraced him and kissed him." Before any negotiation can begin, the father orders the robe, the ring, the sandals, and the feast. The father is not interested in a useful son. He wants his son.

I begin the retreat here because I have watched many people come to God the way the son came home: with a plan for how to be acceptable. They arrive intending to be very disciplined, or very repentant, or very focused, so that by the end of three days they will have earned the right to be received. Some of what you wrote in your intention may have that shape. Some of your resistance in the week before may have been the fear that you would not manage the speech.

The passage says something simpler. Before the son can negotiate his status, the father moves toward him in compassion. The initiative belongs to grace. Whatever you have prepared to say, the welcome does not depend on it.

That is what "come as you are" means. You come as you are because there is no other way to come. You do not come because your present condition is unimportant, but because transformation begins with being received truthfully rather than presenting a repaired version of yourself. Jesus' own invitation in Matthew 11:28 is addressed to "all who labor and are heavy laden," which is a description, not a qualification. The tired, distracted, doubtful, resentful, numb version of you is the one that is invited. There is no other version available to bring.

This first session does not require you to manufacture a particular feeling, complete a spiritual inventory, or produce perfect repentance before God will receive you. If you are already aware of sin that needs confessing, you do not need to postpone it. Name it honestly. But do not imagine that the quality of your remorse purchases the Father's welcome. Repentance is a return to the God whose grace has already made return possible. Session Five will give unhurried space for the deeper kind of confession that surfaces slowly in quiet. For now, the one thing asked of you is that you arrive honestly, present as you are, before a God who has seen you coming for a long time.

Self-assessment

Answer these in your journal, briefly. This is a check-in, not a test.

1. How is your body right now? Tired, restless, tense, heavy, numb, calm? Name it without fixing it.
2. How is your mind? Racing, foggy, anxious, blank, quietly sad?
3. What speech have you prepared? In other words, what have you been planning to prove, achieve, or perform during these days so that the retreat will count?
4. Look back at your Lesson 4 check-in. Does it still describe you today? What has changed since you wrote it, if anything?

Guided prayer

Read this slowly, aloud if you have privacy, or silently. Change any words that are not yours.

Father, I am here. That is the most honest thing I can say. I have come tired, and I have come with explanations, fears, and plans for proving myself. I set those plans down. I cannot earn the welcome you give by grace. You saw me before I began this journey. Help me receive your mercy before I try to explain or improve myself. Let me be honest with you during these days. I place the outcome in your hands. I am here. Amen.

If the language of embrace in the passage is difficult for you, you can pray instead: "Let me know that I am welcomed and safe in your presence."

Now take the intention you wrote in Lesson 7 and read it to God, exactly as you wrote it, including the part you had not said and the line about releasing the outcome. This is the first thing you say to him on the retreat, and it does not need to be improved.

Silence

Suggested length: ten minutes. Adjust to what you can manage, as Lesson 12 described.

Anchor phrase: "While he was still a long way off, his father saw him." Or, if you prefer something shorter: "I am here."

Sit, stand, or walk slowly. When your attention drifts, return to the phrase. You are not trying to feel anything. You are letting yourself be seen.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

Take as long as you need with these. Full sentences are not required.

1. What did you notice during the silence? Thoughts, feelings, physical sensations, nothing in particular. Write it down without interpreting it.
2. The father ran. What is your honest reaction to the idea that God is not waiting for you to arrive properly, but is already moving toward you in compassion? Relief, suspicion, disbelief, indifference? Write the true answer.
3. The son planned to be a servant rather than a son. Where in your life, or your faith, have you been trying to be useful instead of being received?

4. Finish this sentence, and do not think about it too long: "The thing I most need to tell God honestly at the start of this retreat is..."

Practical exercise: setting things down

Take three or four of the index cards from Lesson 10. This exercise has two parts, and the distinction matters.

Bring into the retreat. Some of what you carried here belongs here: grief, anger, spiritual questions, shame, relationships that need prayer, and the central intention you wrote in Lesson 7. Do not seal these away. They are what the next nine sessions are for, even if you approach them gradually.

Set aside until Day 3. Other things you carried in do not need attention during the retreat: routine work tasks, non-urgent emails, shopping and errands, decisions that do not need to be made this week, problems already delegated to someone else. Write these on the cards, one item per line, as specifically as you can. If the list runs to several cards, that is normal.

When the list is complete, read it once. These are real, and they will still be real on the last day. But they are not for now. Put the cards in an envelope, seal it, and write on the front: Not until Day 3. Put the envelope somewhere you will not see it, in your bag or a drawer. You will reopen it during Session Ten.

One exception. The envelope is for non-urgent demands. Do not place a safety concern, a medical need, a crisis, thoughts of harming yourself, or an urgent responsibility inside and tell yourself it must wait until Day 3. Those are handled as Lesson 5 described, now.

You are not throwing anything away. You are giving yourself permission to put the ordinary demands down for three days. The father's house is a place where the pig field does not have the final word. There will be time to tell the truth about where you have been, but your failure is not the only fact about you.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. If a line feels beyond you, change "I" to "I want to believe," "I am willing to consider," or "Help me receive."

I have come as I am. I am seen from a long way off, with compassion. I do not have to earn these days. During this retreat, I will practise laying down performance, and I will begin learning a different way to live when I return.

Be Still and Become Present

Before you begin

You have had a break, a meal, perhaps a walk or a sleep. Before you sit down, notice whether your mind has drifted back to the envelope. That is normal on the first afternoon. Notice it without judgement. Unless you realise that you placed an urgent safety, health, or caregiving matter inside, leave it sealed until Day 3.

Have your Bible, your journal, and your timer. This session is slower than the first, and it contains the longest silence so far. If ten minutes was your limit this morning, stay there. Nothing in this session requires more.

Central passage

Psalm 46

Read the whole psalm twice. The second time, notice how much noise there is in it before verse 10.

Teaching

"Be still, and know that I am God" is one of the most quoted lines in the Bible, and it is almost always quoted out of its setting. Read the psalm from the beginning and the setting is anything but still.

The earth gives way. Mountains fall into the sea. Waters roar and foam. Nations rage and kingdoms totter. Verse 10 arrives in the middle of a world coming apart. In context, the command appears to confront the raging nations: cease, and recognise the God who will be exalted among them. The Hebrew verb can carry the sense of ceasing, letting go, or becoming slack. It is less an invitation to create a peaceful mood than a command to stop striving against God's sovereignty. Its original force is larger than private contemplation, though it can still reshape how an individual believer responds to turmoil.

That matters for this session, because the stillness the psalm describes is not the stillness of a calm world. It is the stillness of a person who knows something true in the middle of a world that is not calm. "God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble." Present. Not distant, not delayed, not waiting for the trouble to end. "Present" does not mean you will necessarily feel calm or experience God vividly. It means that trouble does not place you beyond his knowledge, sovereignty, or care.

Much of the time, our attention is divided. We anticipate what is coming, replay what has happened, and mentally return to responsibilities elsewhere. The body is in the room and the attention is in tomorrow's meeting, last month's conversation, the people at home, the thing we should have said. This is such a normal condition that we rarely notice it, and it is tiring, because we are in two places and fully in neither. Jesus addressed it in the Sermon on the Mount: "do not be anxious about tomorrow, for tomorrow will be anxious for itself. Sufficient for the day is its own trouble" (Matthew 6:34). He is not shaming people who experience anxiety or forbidding wise preparation for tomorrow. He is challenging the attempt to carry tomorrow's burden before tomorrow arrives. For someone living with an anxiety disorder, returning attention to the present may require professional care as well as spiritual practice, and there is no shame in that.

There is a second picture of stillness in the Gospels that belongs beside the psalm. In Mark 4:35–41, Jesus is asleep in the stern of a boat while a storm fills it with water. The disciples, several of them experienced fishermen, are terrified. They wake him, and he speaks to the sea: "Peace! Be still!" The wind and sea become calm. Then he turns to them: "Why are you so afraid? Have you still no faith?"

Jesus was able to sleep while the storm raged. The text may suggest exhaustion, trust, or both, but it does not describe his inner state in detail. When he woke, he spoke with authority, and the calm came from who he was and what he commanded, not from a technique. The disciples' fear was understandable because the danger was real. Jesus' question about faith does not mean that noticing danger is sinful. It exposes how difficult it was for them, in

their terror, to interpret the storm in light of the person who was with them.

This afternoon's work is to become present. Not to make the storms stop, and not to pretend they are not there, but to bring your attention back into the room, into this hour, into this body, and to remember that God is here too. Greater presence can help you engage lament, confession, release, and listening more honestly in the sessions ahead. But divided attention does not disqualify your prayer. God receives you even while you are learning to return.

Self-assessment

Briefly, in your journal:

1. Right now, where is your attention? In this room, or somewhere else? If somewhere else, where: the past, the future, another place, another person?
2. When you try to bring your attention back to now, what pulls it away again? Name the strongest pull.
3. On a scale from "mostly attentive to this room" to "strongly pulled elsewhere," where would you place yourself?
No right answer.
4. What situation currently feels unstable, loud, or beyond your control? Name it in one line without analysing or solving it. If you feel unreal, disconnected from your body, unable to recognise where you are, or as though you are reliving another time, pause the session and use the grounding and support guidance from Lesson 5.

Guided prayer

God, you are a very present help. I have been living somewhere else: ahead of myself, behind myself, beside myself. I bring my attention back to this room, this hour, this body. The storm is real. I am not going to pretend it is not. But Christ is with me in it. Teach me to be still, not because the world has gone quiet, but because you are here. Help me to cease striving for the rest of this day. Amen.

Silence

Suggested length: fifteen minutes. If that is beyond you, return to the length you managed this morning. If it is well within you, stay with fifteen; there is no need to extend it.

Anchor phrase: "Be still, and know that I am God." Or, shorter: "God is here."

Before you begin, spend the first minute simply noticing where you are: the chair or the ground beneath you, the light, the sounds inside and outside the room. Notice only what feels neutral and manageable. If bodily attention increases distress, focus on visible objects, colours, or the words of the psalm instead. Then move to the phrase.

Each time you realise you have travelled somewhere else, the past, the future, the envelope, do not scold yourself. Notice where you went, and come back. The coming back is the practice. Each return is simply part of it. When you return without scolding yourself, you are learning that distraction does not have to become failure.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. Where did your attention go during the silence? List the places. Which one did it return to most often?
2. When have you recognised, or felt, God's help in your life? If you cannot identify such a time, say so honestly. Your inability to recall an experience does not make the psalm's declaration untrue, and Session Seven will return to this.
3. The disciples were afraid because the boat was filling. What reasonable fear makes it difficult for you to remember or trust that Christ remains with you?
4. Finish this sentence: "If I gave this present moment my attention without trying to solve the past or anticipate the future, I would notice..."

Practical exercise: a walk of noticing

This exercise takes twenty to thirty minutes and is best done outdoors, though a window, a garden, a corridor, or a different room will do. If walking is not possible for you, sit somewhere new, ideally with a view, and do the same exercise without moving. Use mobility aids or remain seated as needed.

Leave ordinary digital input behind. If safety permits, leave the phone in your room. If you need it for emergencies, carry it out of sight with your retreat setting active and only the designated contact permitted to ring through. Do not use it for photographs, messages, music, or checking information during the walk.

Walk at a comfortable, unhurried pace that is safe for your body and surroundings, and give your attention to one sense at a time.

For the first few minutes, notice only what you can see. Colours, light, movement, small things you would normally walk past. You may simply observe, or quietly name what you see if that helps you stay oriented. The purpose is not to analyse or evaluate it.

Then, for a few minutes, notice only what you can hear. The near sounds and the far ones. The sounds you would normally filter out.

Then what you can feel: the ground under your feet, the air on your skin, the temperature, your own breathing if that is comfortable for you.

Then, if you are outdoors, what you can smell.

Finally, walk the last few minutes with all of it at once, simply present in the place where you are, repeating your anchor phrase if it helps.

If focusing closely on one sense becomes uncomfortable, use whichever sense feels most neutral, or take in the environment more generally. You do not have to complete every stage.

This is not a technique for producing a spiritual experience, and you may feel nothing in particular. The purpose is practice in being where you are. Present-moment attention can often be strengthened through practice, though each person's capacity is affected by health, exhaustion, trauma, and how their mind works. The goal is not perfect concentration but repeated, compassionate return. The retreat will ask you to be present many times in the next two days. This is the first rehearsal.

If you feel unsafe, faint, confused, severely distressed, or disoriented, stop moving and go to the nearest safe, familiar place. Contact your designated person or appropriate help. Do not continue walking, and do not drive, while disoriented. Do not walk somewhere unfamiliar or unsafe in the name of noticing.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

God is a very present help. The storm is real, and Christ is with me in it. I am learning to be here, in this hour, in this place. Every time I wander, I will come back.

Day 2: Release and Tell the Truth

This is what Richmond says in the day's introduction video. Read it before the first session of the day.

Good morning.

If you slept well, thank God for it. If you did not, that is not a failure. Day 2 can still hold what it needs to hold.

Before you open your Bible, take care of your body. Eat something. Drink something. Take your medication according to your normal plan. Give yourself a few quiet minutes with your drink.

You are not late.

If you feel unwell, adjust the day or let the sessions wait. Your body does not have to be ignored for the retreat to be spiritual.

Day 1 was about arriving. Day 2 is about releasing what you have carried and telling the truth about it.

This is the deeper part of the retreat. It will still be gentle, and it will still move at your pace. But some of what surfaces today may feel heavy. You are not required to resolve all of it.

Your first session is called "Release What You Are Carrying."

You will sit with the invitation of Jesus: "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden." Receive those words personally. They are addressed to tired people, and that includes you.

You will then sort what you are carrying into four groups: something requiring action, something to share with another person, something requiring counsel or additional help, and something to entrust to God.

You will write these on cards. Keep them safe; they will come home with you.

This afternoon's session is "Lament, Grief, and Honest Prayer."

You will pray through Psalm 13, which begins with the unguarded question, "How long, O LORD?" It is a prayer that does not pretend.

The practical exercise offers three levels of depth. Choose the one you can safely hold today. All three are complete. The deepest option is not automatically the most faithful one.

The evening session, "Confession and Grace," is optional tonight. Complete it only if you are rested and settled. If you are not, leave it for tomorrow morning. The schedule has room for that.

Session Six, on forgiveness, is not part of today or the core three-day retreat. If it is ever appropriate for you, it can be completed later—possibly with support. Forgiveness is not something you must finish on a schedule.

Remember three things today.

First, feelings that surface are not problems you must solve before continuing. Name them and write them down. Let the sessions give them somewhere to go.

Second, if anything brings up more than you can safely hold, stop. Open your eyes. Stand and move. Orient yourself to the room or go outside if it is safe. Contact your support person when you need to.

Pausing is not failing.

Third, God met Elijah beneath the broom tree with food, water, and sleep before asking anything more of him.

God is not in a hurry with you either.

Take your Bible, journal, cards, and timer.

When you are ready, begin.

Release What You Are Carrying

Before you begin

Good morning. If you slept well, thank God for it. If you did not, that is not a failure; Day 2 will still hold. Follow the food and medication plan you established in Lesson 11, and do not begin this emotionally demanding session hungry, dehydrated, medically unstable, or physically unwell. Give yourself a few minutes of quiet with your drink before you open the Bible. You are not late.

This session begins the deeper part of the retreat. It is still gentle, and it still moves at your pace. But it asks you to look at what you have been carrying, and some of that may be heavy. If the session brings up more than you can safely hold, stop. That may mean pausing the exercise, ending the session, or ending the retreat and seeking appropriate support. Let safety, not completion, determine the next step.

Central passage

Matthew 11:28–30

Read the passage twice as written, the second time slowly, pausing after each phrase. Then pause and hear Christ's invitation as addressed to you personally: "Come to me, [your name]..."

Teaching

Lesson 1 quoted this passage, and you may know it well. Familiarity is the danger. It is possible to have heard "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden" so many times that it no longer lands, so this session will try to hear it again, in the three movements the passage itself makes.

Come to me. Rest begins in relationship with Christ, not in a technique. Matthew does not limit "all who labor and are heavy laden" to one kind of burden. Yet elsewhere he records Jesus condemning religious leaders who "tie up heavy burdens, hard to bear, and lay them on people's shoulders" without lifting a finger to help (Matthew 23:4). It is therefore appropriate to include religious exhaustion among the burdens you may bring, while not reducing the invitation to that alone. Some of what you are carrying may have been laid on you in God's name. It is still a burden, and Jesus still says "Come."

Take my yoke. Notice that he does not say, "I will take your yoke away." A yoke was associated with labour and submission, and it became a natural image in Jewish teaching for accepting a teacher's authority and way of life. To take Jesus' yoke is to become his disciple: to place yourself under his teaching and learn his manner of obedience. Jesus does not merely offer a temporary break. He calls people to himself, places them under his teaching, and invites them to learn his way of life. The rest and the discipleship belong together.

So the difference lies not in the absence of a yoke but in the character of the teacher. The word translated "easy" carries the sense of something kind, good, or gracious rather than harsh.

Jesus' yoke is still a yoke; discipleship involves obedience. But its master is "gentle and lowly in heart," not cruel or oppressive. He does not drive his disciples through fear, humiliation, or endless attempts to prove their worth. If you have been driving yourself that way, you have been wearing someone else's yoke.

Learn from me. The rest he offers is not only relief; it is a different way of living, learned under a gentle Lord. You will not learn it in a morning. But you can begin.

This matters for the practical work of the session, because "release" can be misunderstood. Some people hear it as "drop everything," and then feel guilty because their children still need feeding and their work still needs doing. That is not what Jesus offers, and it is not what this session asks. In this session, release means four things: entrusting what you cannot control, sharing what should not be carried alone, taking faithful action on what

genuinely belongs to you, and seeking counsel where responsibility is unclear.

On entrusting: release the attempt to control what lies outside your authority. You may still have a faithful response to make, but you are not responsible for producing another person's choice or guaranteeing an outcome. Some expectations placed on you are unhealthy, manipulative, or inconsistent with Scripture. Others may represent legitimate responsibilities you do not want to face. Do not make that distinction from feeling alone; test it through Scripture, wise counsel, and the actual commitments you have made.

On sharing: 1 Peter 5:7 says to cast "all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you." Peter does not promise that responsibilities disappear. He invites believers to place their anxieties into God's care while humbling themselves under his mighty hand (verse 6). You still take faithful action, but you do not act as though your strength controls every outcome. And prayer may bring relief, but an anxiety disorder is not proof that someone has refused to cast their cares on God. Professional treatment, medication, practical support, and spiritual trust can belong together.

One caution before the exercise. Some burdens are the direct result of harm done to you, and "release" is not a way of pretending the harm did not happen or of relieving the person who caused it of responsibility. Entrusting the outcome to God does not mean withdrawing a report, abandoning a safety plan, cancelling a boundary, concealing wrongdoing, or relieving an offender of accountability. Release is not silence, reconciliation, or surrender to further harm. If what you carry includes abuse, injustice, or serious wrong done against you, this session is not asking you to let that go. Sessions Four and Six will give those things their own space.

Self-assessment

In your journal, make a list. Take ten minutes or more. Write down everything you are carrying right now: responsibilities, worries, fears, hopes you are holding for other people, expectations, guilt, unresolved situations. Do not sort them yet. Include the things that feel too small to mention. Include what you can name safely; if something feels too large, write only a general word such as "grief," "harm," or "something for professional support." You do not need to record details.

When the list is done, read it once, and then answer:

1. How long is the list? Did it surprise you?
2. Which item on it has been there longest?
3. Which item most affects your daily capacity? What kind of support, change, or faithful response might make it more manageable?

Guided prayer

Jesus, you said to come to you, and I have come. I am carrying more than I can hold, and I have been carrying it as if no one else would. Some of it is mine to act on. Some of it I cannot control. Some of it I should not carry alone. I cannot always tell the difference. Teach me. Show me what to entrust, what to share, and what to do. I take your yoke, because you are gentle and lowly in heart. I cast on you the anxiety I have been holding, because you said you care. Give me rest, not from responsibility, but from carrying it as though everything depends on me. Amen.

Silence

Suggested length: fifteen minutes, or the length you can manage.

Anchor phrase: "Come to me, and I will give you rest." Or, shorter: "Gentle and lowly in heart."

Sit with your list in front of you if that is helpful, or close the journal if it is not. Do not work on the list during the silence. Simply be in the presence of the one who said "Come," with everything you have written still in the room. Notice which item your attention returns to, but do not assume repetition makes it the one you must address. You will choose where to begin based on safety, readiness, and wisdom.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. Go back through your list and mark each item with one or more of these letters. An item can carry more than one; "A/E" might mean take the action that belongs to me and entrust the result.

Mark	Meaning	Question to ask
A — Act	Something within my responsibility or control	What is the next faithful action?
S — Share	A burden needing practical, pastoral, relational, or professional support	Who should help carry this?
E — Entrust	An outcome or choice I cannot control	What am I trying to guarantee that belongs to God or to another person?
? — Seek counsel	Responsibility is unclear or potentially serious	Whose qualified wisdom do I need?

1. Look at the items marked E. What have you been trying to guarantee? Where did the sense that it was yours to guarantee come from?
2. Look at the items marked S. For each, name the kind of help it needs: a friend, a spouse, a pastor, a doctor, a counsellor, a colleague, a professional service.
3. Look at the items marked?. For each, name the right kind of guidance. A pastor or counsellor is not the correct authority for every burden; some need a doctor or mental-health professional, a domestic-abuse specialist, a safeguarding leader, a lawyer or financial adviser, an employer or HR representative, or a trusted family member.
4. Was anything on the list laid on you in God's name that Jesus might describe as a heavy burden, hard to bear? Write about it honestly. If you are not sure, say so.

Practical exercise: handing over

Take the index cards. Write one card per item, using the category it received. The wording below is a starting point; use your own words if they are truer.

Entrust cards: "I cannot control _____. I release my demand to guarantee the outcome. Show me any faithful action that still belongs to me."

Share cards: "I need help carrying _____. The person or service I will approach is _____."

Act cards: "The next faithful step within my responsibility is _____. I do not have to solve everything today."

Seek-counsel cards: "I will not make this decision alone. I will seek appropriate guidance from _____."

Read each card to God, aloud if you have privacy. Then place the Entrust cards face down somewhere set apart, under your Bible, in front of the cross if you brought one, or in an envelope marked with today's date. The location has no spiritual power. It is simply a physical way of marking the decision you have made in prayer. You are not destroying these; you may want to look at them again on Day 3 or after the retreat.

Keep the Share, Act, and Seek-counsel cards together. They go back into your ordinary life with you, and Module 5 will help you turn them into a plan.

If any card, at any point, brings up more than you can hold, stop, set it aside, and use the pause guidance from Lesson 5. That card can wait for Session Four, Session Six, or a conversation with the right person after the retreat.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

I have come to Christ, who gives rest. I release my demand to control what is beyond me. I will seek help with what should be shared. I will take the next faithful step in what belongs to me. Christ is gentle and humble in heart, and I am learning his way.

Lament, Grief, and Honest Prayer

Before you begin

You have had a real break since Session Three. If you have not, take one now. This session should not be entered tired, hungry, or directly on the heels of the handing-over exercise.

This session may bring grief or anger closer to the surface, but that is not something you must force. Its purpose is to give honest, prayerful expression to what you can safely acknowledge today. Please read the boundaries before you start. You are in charge of how far you go. You may stop at any point, and you may leave anything untouched.

If you have a trauma history and exercises involving memory, grief, or silence tend to trigger panic, flashbacks, dissociation, or severe distress, use the supported format or plan this session with a qualified trauma-informed professional. A designated friend can be a steadying presence but is not necessarily equipped to manage a trauma reaction. If your loss is very recent, traumatic, or currently overwhelming your ability to function, you may skip this session entirely and choose simple companionship, rest, or supported prayer instead. You do not need to process a major loss according to the retreat's timetable.

Have tissues nearby. It is not a sign of anything; it is practical.

Central passage

Psalm 13

It is six verses. Read it three times: once quickly, once slowly, and once noticing where the psalm turns.

Teaching

Depending on how they are classified, laments make up roughly a third of the Psalms and are often described as the Psalter's largest category. That is worth pausing over. The book that has shaped Jewish and Christian prayer for centuries contains far more complaint, grief, protest, and unanswered questioning than many Christians expect, and God kept all of it. Whatever you have been taught, explicitly or by example, about keeping your prayers positive, the psalmists were not taught it.

Psalm 13 is a lament in miniature, and it displays a common lament movement: address, complaint, petition, and renewed trust. Not every biblical lament contains every movement or places them in the same order, but this one shows the shape clearly. It begins by addressing God directly: "How long, O LORD?" Four times in two verses the psalmist asks how long, and the questions are not polite. Will you forget me forever? Will you hide your face? Must I carry sorrow all day? Must my enemy win? Then it turns to petition: consider me, answer me, light up my eyes. And then, in the final two verses, it turns again, to trust: "But I have trusted in your steadfast love... I will sing to the LORD, because he has dealt bountifully with me."

Notice what the psalm does not do. It does not skip the first four verses to get to the last two. It does not apologise for the questions. In the poem, the declaration of trust comes after complaint and petition. That does not necessarily mean the pain has ended. It shows that trust can be spoken while the situation remains unresolved, and that it is a decision as much as a feeling: "I have trusted." Address, complaint, petition, trust. That is a pattern, and it is a permission.

Not every lament reaches the trust. Psalm 88 ends, "You have caused my beloved and my friend to shun me; my companions have become darkness." No turn, no resolution, no song. Lesson 4 mentioned it, and it belongs here as well. Scripture makes room for prayer that ends in the dark. If your lament today does not reach the final verses of Psalm 13, you have not prayed wrongly. Your prayer may resemble Psalm 88 in ending without visible resolution, and that kind of prayer is also in the book.

Grief in particular needs this permission, because much of what people carry into a retreat is grief they have never had time or permission to feel. Some of it is the obvious kind: a death, a diagnosis, a divorce, a miscarriage. But much of it is less visible. The ministry that did not become what you hoped. The marriage that is not what you prayed for. The friendship that faded without a reason. The version of yourself you expected to be by now. The child who has walked away from faith. The church that hurt you. The body that no longer does what it did. These losses often have no funeral and no casserole, and so they are carried privately, sometimes for years, as a heaviness with no name.

Jesus wept at the tomb of Lazarus (John 11:35). John does not fully explain everything contained in his tears; grief, compassion, and indignation at death may all be present. But the scene shows that the coming resurrection did not make tears inappropriate in the presence of death and human sorrow. And on the cross, Jesus prayed the opening words of Psalm 22, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Mark 15:34), entering the language of lament at the height of his suffering. The psalm itself eventually moves toward vindication, but Jesus did not skip its cry of abandonment. If lament was appropriate for him, it is appropriate for you.

One more thing, because some readers need to hear it. Scripture permits us to bring anger, protest, confusion, and even accusation directly to God rather than disguising them with religious language. At the end of Job, God rebuked Job's friends and said Job had spoken rightly in a way they had not (Job 42:7); yet Job also acknowledged the limits of his understanding (Job 42:3–6). Together, these passages make room for honest protest without suggesting that every accusation made in grief is a complete description of God. Jeremiah used startling language, telling God that he felt deceived or overpowered (Jeremiah 20:7, depending on translation). The psalmists asked whether God was asleep (Psalm 44:23). Honest prayer does not mean that every conclusion we draw about God is correct. It means we bring the real conclusion to him, where it can be heard, challenged, and transformed.

Anger that cannot be acknowledged may deepen isolation. Bringing it to God can be a beginning. But if you cannot yet do that, your silence does not place you beyond grace. You may need the presence of another person before words become possible.

Self-assessment

In your journal, gently:

1. Is there a loss in your life that has received little space, support, or acknowledgment? Name it in a word or a phrase, or in a general word if a specific one is too much.
2. Is there something about which you feel angry, disappointed, confused, or abandoned in relation to God? Write it down without softening it.
3. When you read Psalm 13's questions, which one is closest to your own: forgetting, hiding, sorrow, an enemy prevailing, or another phrase from the psalm?
4. What have you been told, or told yourself, about whether it is acceptable to pray like this? If any answer brings up more than you can hold, stop here, and use the pause guidance from Lesson 5. You can return to the rest of the session later, or not at all.

Guided prayer

Use only the lines that fit your experience. Change or omit the others.

God, I have been carrying grief I did not have time to feel, and anger I did not think I was allowed to say. You kept the laments. You kept Psalm 88. Help me risk bringing you one honest question. How long? I do not understand why _____. I am tired of _____. I have lost _____, and I have not been able to say so until now. Consider me. Answer me. Light up my eyes. I do not have the last verses yet. Meet me in the first four. Amen.

Fill in the blanks aloud or silently, or leave them empty if the words will not come.

Silence

Suggested length: ten minutes. This is deliberately shorter than the previous session. If you are already at capacity, five minutes is enough, or none.

Anchor phrase: "How long, O LORD?" Or, if that is too raw today: "Consider and answer me."

Do not try to feel anything in this silence, and do not try to stop feeling anything. If tears come, let them. If nothing comes, that is also permitted. God's presence is not suspended until your grief becomes orderly or your prayer reaches a hopeful conclusion.

If the silence becomes more than sorrow, if it moves into panic, disconnection, or a sense of reliving rather than remembering, stop, open your eyes, and use the orientation exercise from Lesson 5. Contact your support person if you need to. If the reaction is severe, persistent, or includes danger to yourself, contact a qualified professional, crisis service, or emergency service rather than relying only on your designated person.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. What did you find yourself grieving, or angry about, during the silence? Write it in whatever detail feels safe.
2. Psalm 13 moves through address, complaint, petition, and trust. Which of those four have you been skipping in your own prayers? Which have you been stuck in?
3. What loss have you felt unable or unwilling to grieve openly, because you believed you should be past it, or because hope seemed to forbid sorrow? Tears are one expression of grief, not the measure of whether grief is real.
4. Write one sentence that begins "God, I do not understand why..." and finish it truthfully.

Practical exercise: writing your own lament

Choose your level before you begin. All three are complete exercises.

- Brief lament: one sentence of complaint and one request.
- General lament: the four parts below, using broad words without names or details.
- Full lament: the four parts below, in whatever detail feels safe and appropriate. Using Psalm 13 as a template, write a lament of your own. It does not need to be long, and it does not need to be poetic.

1. Address. Speak to God directly, by whatever name is yours for him.
2. Complaint. Say what is wrong. Be specific if you can be safely, general if you cannot. Ask "how long?" if that is your question. Do not soften it, and do not add "but I know you have a plan" unless you actually mean it in this moment.
3. Petition. Ask for what you want, not for what you think you should want. The psalmist asked for his eyes to be lit up so that he would not die. You may tell God even the desire you know is confused, impossible, or wrong. Naming a desire is not endorsing it, and writing it does not give permission to act upon harm. If you feel at risk of harming yourself or someone else, stop and seek immediate help.
4. Trust. If you can write a confident statement of trust, write it. If you cannot, leave the space blank, write "not yet," or name the smallest truth you can still hold: "I am still speaking," "I

want to believe," "I do not know how to leave." Addressing God honestly may itself be the only trust available today, and Psalm 88 gives you that permission. A blank fourth part is an honest lament, not a failed one. When it is written, read it to God, aloud if you have privacy. Then keep it. Do not tear it up. This is a prayer, and you may want it again. Some people find that returning to their lament weeks later shows them how far they have moved, or shows them that the fourth part has quietly written itself.

If the writing opens something you did not expect, stop when you need to. You do not have to finish the lament today. An unfinished lament is still prayer.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

I have spoken as honestly as I can today. My grief does not disqualify me from God's presence. I do not have to be finished with sorrow in order to pray. Where trust is difficult, I am willing to remain with one honest word, or to receive support until words return.

Confession and Grace

Before you begin

If you are beginning this session on the evening of Day 2, make sure you have genuinely rested since the lament. If you are beginning on the morning of Day 3, welcome back. Either way, begin only after genuine rest and when you have sufficient emotional capacity. Follow your food and medication plan, and give yourself a few quiet minutes before you start.

This session is about confession, and I want to say at the outset what it is not. It is not an interrogation. It is not a search for hidden sins to explain your dryness; Lesson 4 and Lesson 8 both said that dryness is not always caused by sin, and that remains true. It is not a session for people to punish themselves. This is a session about grace. Confession is not how you persuade God to become merciful; it is how you step honestly into the mercy God has already revealed.

If you have diagnosed or suspected scrupulosity, or a pattern of repeated confession, moral checking, and reassurance-seeking, please read the paragraph on scrupulosity in the teaching before deciding whether to do the exercise at all.

Central passage

Psalm 51:1–12

Read it twice. The second time, notice how much of it is about God's character and how little of it is about the details of what David did.

Teaching

The traditional heading connects Psalm 51 with Nathan's confrontation of David after his sin involving Bathsheba and Uriah, the story told in 2 Samuel 11–12. David abused his royal power, summoned Bathsheba, slept with her, and then arranged the death of her husband, Uriah, in an attempt to conceal what had happened. He continued as king until Nathan confronted him with a story about a rich man who stole a poor man's lamb. David condemned the rich man, and Nathan said, "You are the man." Psalm 51 is the prayer the heading associates with what came next.

It is worth reading with the story in mind, because Psalm 51 is not the prayer of a person with a vague sense of unworthiness. It is the prayer of a person who has done real and serious harm and knows it. David's first words appeal to God's steadfast love and abundant mercy: "Have mercy on me, O God, according to your steadfast love; according to your abundant mercy blot out my transgressions." He does not begin by minimising the wrong or defending himself; he begins by asking the merciful God to deal with it. That order is the whole theology of confession. Christian confession rests not on our ability to feel certain but on God's revealed character and the mercy given in Christ.

Two things in the psalm need careful handling. First, David says, "Against you, you only, have I sinned." That is not a claim that Bathsheba and Uriah were unharmed. David's words place his sin under God's judgement, but they must not be read as erasing the people he harmed. The verse uses intensely God-centred language; it does not teach that sins against people are only private matters between the offender and God. Confession to God and accountability for human harm belong together. Lesson 8 said this, and it holds here. David's own consequences, within the narrative, were severe and lasting. This does not mean that every hardship following confession should be interpreted as divine punishment. It means that forgiveness does not automatically reverse relational, legal, professional, or practical consequences.

Second, the psalm does not end in the dirt. It moves toward restoration: "Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me... Restore to me the joy of your salvation." David does not ask to be tolerated. He asks to be made new and to have joy back. Psalm 51 allows the penitent person to ask for restored joy. That joy may return gradually and may require relational repair, treatment, and time. A lack of immediate relief does not mean the confession was invalid.

Lesson 8 asked you to confess known sin before you came, the kind you could already name. This session allows you to consider whether a recurring attitude, choice, or pattern has become clearer during the retreat. Silence is not an infallible detector of sin. It can also produce memories, fears, intrusive thoughts, mistaken interpretations, and self-criticism, so anything that surfaces must be tested rather than automatically confessed. Patterns can help explain how repeated incidents became possible, but they do not replace responsibility for particular actions. Both may need to be named.

Not every limitation is sin. Exhaustion, numbness, intrusive thoughts, fear, illness, trauma responses, and the need for boundaries are not automatically moral failures. This matters especially for a burned-out reader, who may be tempted to confess emptiness as though it were cruelty. Ask whether you knowingly chose deception, cruelty, manipulation, neglect, exploitation, or another violation of love, not merely whether you felt afraid, empty, or unavailable. A simple set of questions helps:

- What did I choose?
- Who was affected?
- What truth or responsibility did I knowingly avoid?
- Was this wrongdoing, a human limitation, a symptom, or some combination?
- Do I need confession, care, boundaries, treatment, repair, or more than one of these? The New Testament gives the promise plainly. 1 John 1:9: "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness." God is faithful to his promise and just because forgiveness rests in Christ's saving work, not in the emotional intensity or perfect wording of our confession. And Luke 7:36–50 gives the picture: a woman known in the town as a sinner weeps at Jesus' feet while a religious host looks on with contempt, and Jesus says of her, "her sins, which are many, are forgiven, for she loved much," and then, "he who is forgiven little, loves little." The woman's love does not purchase forgiveness. Her actions reveal the depth with which she has received mercy, while Simon's coldness exposes how little he recognises his own need. Recognising mercy can enlarge humility, gratitude, and love. Concealing sin, by contrast, can make genuine relationship more difficult.

A necessary word about scrupulosity. If you have diagnosed or suspected scrupulosity, repeated confession, moral checking, reassurance-seeking, and attempts to achieve perfect certainty may be compulsions rather than spiritually useful practices. Do not use this session to create a new rule about how many times or how perfectly you must confess. Follow the plan developed with a clinician who understands OCD and respects your faith. You may skip the written confession exercise entirely and use only a brief, familiar prayer consistent with your treatment plan. The goal is not to obtain a particular feeling of certainty through repetition. If repeating a confession functions as reassurance or compulsion, pause and follow professional guidance. A pastor may collaborate with that treatment but should not replace it.

And a word about the serious. If what surfaces is a sin that involved harm to another person, abuse, exploitation, criminal conduct, professional misconduct, or someone's present safety, confess it to God, and then seek qualified guidance about accountability, reporting, restitution, and appropriate disclosure. Do not use this session, or a later confidential conversation, to avoid a responsibility that needs to be faced in the open.

Self-assessment

Gently, in your journal. This is a review of a season, not a hunt.

1. Has a repeated choice or relational pattern become clearer during the retreat? If so, name it.

2. Did that pattern involve actual wrongdoing, a human limitation, a health or trauma response, or some combination? Use the five questions above.
3. Who was affected, and what impact can you responsibly acknowledge?
4. What does Psalm 51:1 reveal about the mercy to which you are bringing this? Write it before you write anything else. If nothing comes, do not manufacture it. Some readers will find that the honest answer is "I do not see a pattern," and that is an acceptable answer. Move to the prayer.

Guided prayer

Use only the lines that fit. Change or omit the others.

Have mercy on me, O God, according to your steadfast love. Before I say what I have done, I say what you are like: faithful, just, abundant in mercy. I have seen something in these days that I did not see before: _____. I have chosen _____ when I knew better. I have avoided _____. I do not offer excuses. I offer this to you. Create in me a clean heart. Restore to me the joy of your salvation. I will trust that you have done what you said, whether or not I feel it yet. Amen.

Silence

Suggested length: fifteen minutes, or the length you can manage.

Anchor phrase: "According to your steadfast love." Or, shorter: "Have mercy on me."

An unwanted thought, image, impulse, or memory is not automatically a sin, a confession, an intention, or a revelation of your character. Do not confess a thought merely because it appeared.

In this silence, do not scan for sins. Rest in the first verse of the psalm. If you remember a specific choice or pattern that may require attention, write it down for later discernment. Do not interpret every thought or feeling as evidence of sin. If nothing comes, rest in the mercy. Both are the session.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. What, if anything, surfaced during the silence? Write it plainly, without excuse and without exaggeration, and then apply the five questions to it.
2. David's consequences did not disappear when he was forgiven. Is there any repair, apology, or accountability that your confession points toward once you are home? Write what it is and who it involves. If it is serious in the way described above, write only the name of the qualified person you will consult.
3. Has concealment, defensiveness, or refusal to take responsibility affected your ability to love someone well? If so, how?
4. If I began living from the assurance of forgiveness while still accepting appropriate consequences, one possible change would be...

Practical exercise: confession and assurance of forgiveness

If the scrupulosity paragraph applies to you, you may skip this exercise and use a brief, familiar prayer instead.

Take one or two index cards. Write your confession on a card, in the plainest words you can, without softening and without self-punishment. If it is a pattern rather than an incident, name the pattern. If more than one thing surfaced, use a card for each. Do not record names, identifying details, illegal conduct, abuse details, or information that could endanger another person if discovered. Use general language and keep the envelope secure. For serious matters, record only the name of the qualified professional you will contact.

Read each card to God, aloud if you have privacy. Then, with the cards in front of you, read aloud these two passages:

"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness." (1 John 1:9)

"As far as the east is from the west, so far does he remove our transgressions from us." (Psalm 103:12)

Receive these passages as promises given to God's people and applicable to those who come to him in repentance and faith. This is not a ritual with power of its own. It is you hearing, in God's own words, what he has said about what you have just brought him.

Then put the cards in an envelope and seal it. Write on the front the word *Forgiven* and today's date. You are not destroying the cards, for the same reason as before: nothing on this retreat is destroyed. But this envelope is different from the others. You do not need to open it again. Some readers keep it as a reminder of the date; some, weeks later, dispose of it at home as an act of closing. Either is fine. The sealed envelope symbolises that confession has been placed under God's promise of forgiveness. It does not close questions of accountability, repair, reporting, or continuing care.

If any card also carries an action, an apology, a repair, a consultation, copy that action onto one of the *Act or Seekcounsel* cards from Session Three before you seal the envelope. The confession is answered; the action is still yours.

James 5:16 places confession and prayer within Christian community: "confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, that you may be healed." Some sins should be acknowledged to people directly affected; others may benefit from carefully chosen pastoral accountability. Not every private sin must be disclosed broadly, and not every trusted friend is equipped to receive serious information. Seek guidance before disclosing abuse, criminal conduct, sexual misconduct, professional violations, or information that affects another person's safety. Before disclosing a serious matter, ask what confidentiality the person can and cannot offer; pastors, counsellors, teachers, and other professionals may have reporting obligations. The other person's role is support and accountability. God's forgiveness does not depend on their hearing it. Module 5 will return to this.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

God's steadfast love is revealed before my confession begins. I have named what I can see, without exaggeration or excuse. In Christ, forgiveness rests on God's faithfulness, not the intensity of my feelings. I will accept both mercy and the faithful actions that accountability requires. (Optional:) Forgiven much, I am free to love much.

Forgiving Others and Yourself

Optional session: for the at-home format, the 30-day follow-up, or a supported setting. Not part of the standard three-day schedule.

Before you begin

This session is optional, and it is not in the standard three-day program. Sessions Four and Five both said it may be deferred, and the three-day schedule in Module 3 does not include it. It belongs in the at-home format, where it has its own day; in the 30-day plan in Module 5; or in a supported setting with a pastor, counsellor, or trauma-informed professional. Read this section and decide honestly whether now is the time.

Consider proceeding if you are sufficiently rested and settled, the harm is no longer active, and you want to explore what forgiveness might mean without forcing a final outcome. Defer for any reason that makes today feel unsuitable. You do not need to prove that your reason is valid.

If the harm you carry is abuse, Lesson 5's guidance applies throughout. You are not required to forgive on a schedule, you are never required to contact or return to someone who harmed you, and the default exercise at the end is written specifically with you in mind. If exercises involving the person who harmed you tend to trigger panic, flashbacks, or dissociation, plan this session with a trauma-informed professional rather than doing it alone. If someone monitors your belongings or writing, do not create or keep anything that could place you at risk; pray without writing.

Five movements, not one

Much of the confusion around forgiveness comes from asking one word to do five different jobs. This session separates them, and the rest of it will use these terms.

Movement	Meaning
Truth	Naming the wrong without minimising it
Safety	Ending exposure to continuing harm
Justice	Reporting, restitution, consequences, and protection
Release	Relinquishing personal vengeance and the compulsion to collect
Reconciliation	Possible only with repentance, safety, and rebuilt trust

You can unilaterally relinquish personal vengeance, pray for freedom from hatred, establish boundaries, and entrust judgement to God. Some Christians call that forgiveness; others reserve "forgiveness" for a relational response to repentance. This course uses "release" for the unilateral decision and "reconciliation" for a restored relationship. Reconciliation always requires more than one person. Release, truth, safety, and justice do not wait for the other person.

Central passage

Matthew 18:21–35

Read it twice. The second time, notice both the mercy and the warning.

Teaching

Peter asked Jesus how many times he should forgive his brother, and suggested seven, which he apparently regarded as a generous number. Jesus' answer, seventy-seven or seventy times seven depending on the translation, refuses to turn forgiveness into a tally. Then he told a story.

A servant owes a king ten thousand talents. A talent represented an enormous amount, commonly estimated at many years of a labourer's income, and ten thousand of them creates an intentionally impossible debt. The king forgives it entirely. The same servant then finds a fellow servant who owes him a hundred denarii, still a substantial sum, roughly a hundred days' wages, but tiny beside the first amount, and has him thrown into prison. The king hears of it, and the story ends with a severe warning.

The parable contains both extravagant mercy and that warning, and both need to be held. The warning should never be used to coerce traumatised people into declaring forgiveness on demand. Yet Jesus does confront the contradiction of receiving mercy while cultivating a settled refusal to extend mercy to others. That challenge must be heard within the larger biblical framework of repentance, justice, safety, and patient spiritual formation, not as a threat hanging over a wounded person. We do not purchase God's grace by performing forgiveness correctly. At the same time, Jesus treats a merciless heart as spiritually serious. Christians have differed over how repentance relates to interpersonal forgiveness, but Scripture consistently forbids personal vengeance and calls believers toward mercy. Colossians 3:13 puts it this way: "as the Lord has forgiven you, so you also must forgive." The mercy you have received is the starting point, not a debt you must now repay by forgiving.

It is worth noticing what comes just before the parable. Matthew 18:15–17 describes a process for dealing with a brother who has sinned against you: go to him, then take witnesses, then involve the community. Forgiveness in Matthew 18 sits inside a framework of truth-telling and accountability. It is not the same as pretending nothing happened. But these steps are not a universal procedure for abuse, criminal conduct, coercive control, or situations involving unequal power. In such cases, do not begin with private confrontation. Seek specialist, safeguarding, legal, or law-enforcement guidance as appropriate.

Now let me say plainly what release is not, because most of the reasons people cannot forgive are really reasons they cannot do something else that has been wrongly called forgiveness.

It is not saying the harm did not matter. Truth comes first. You cannot release a debt that was never owed, and you are invited to trust that God sees the wrong truthfully and does not require you to deny its seriousness.

It is not forgetting. Joseph, in Genesis 50:15–21, eventually rejected vengeance, reassured his brothers, and provided for them, and he remembered every detail: "you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good." Remembering is not the opposite of releasing.

It is not reconciliation. Genesis 42–44 shows Joseph testing his brothers at length, with truth coming to light and evidence of change, before the relationship was openly restored. Genesis does not tell us the moment Joseph inwardly released them, so we should not assign an order it does not give. But the story resists the idea that mercy requires immediate trust.

It is not the removal of safety, boundaries, or justice. You can release personal vengeance and still not let the person near your children, still report what they did, still leave, still refuse to work with them again. Release relinquishes vengeance and the desire to inflict suffering for its own sake. It does not necessarily surrender a legitimate claim to restitution, compensation, repayment, reporting, or legal remedy. Those may be part of justice and protection rather than revenge. Romans 12:19 forbids personal vengeance: "never avenge yourselves, but leave it to the wrath of God." It does not remove public justice; in the next chapter Paul describes governing authority as accountable for responding to wrongdoing (Romans 13:1–4). Leaving vengeance to God does not mean preventing lawful authorities, churches, employers, or safeguarding bodies from carrying out their responsibilities.

It is not reducible to a feeling, and it is not always completed by one decision. Release may involve an initial choice against vengeance, repeated prayer, grief, changes in desire, and a long process of healing. Feelings do not have to change on command. And the return of pain or anger does not prove that release failed or must be performed again. A memory can hurt after a genuine decision against vengeance. Respond to what the memory needs, grief, grounding, boundaries, treatment, or renewed prayer, without turning forgiveness into a repetitive test.

It is not required to be spoken to the person. In many cases it should not be. Release is between you and God. Whether the other person ever knows is a separate question, and sometimes the answer is that they must not.

A word about "forgiving yourself." Scripture does not quite use the phrase, and the difference matters. You are not the judge in your own case. What you can do is receive the verdict God has given: "There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (Romans 8:1). Even after receiving forgiveness, a person may continue to feel guilt or shame. That does not automatically mean they are rejecting God. They may need time, restitution, pastoral care, or professional help to integrate what forgiveness means. It helps to separate four things. Healthy conviction identifies wrongdoing and moves toward confession and repair. Shame says the whole person is beyond grace. Consequences address what must still be repaired or protected. Self-punishment attempts to pay for guilt through suffering. In Christian terms, "forgiving yourself" can mean ceasing deliberate self-punishment, accepting that God's mercy is not earned through continued misery, and undertaking repair without making suffering into payment.

Finally, about people who have died, or who are gone, or who will never acknowledge what they did. Release does not require them. It happens before God, whether or not the other person is in the room.

Self-assessment

Gently, in your journal:

1. Is there a person whose actions still carry unresolved grief, anger, fear, or a desire for justice in you? Name them, or use an initial, or write nothing identifying.
2. Which of those responses needs grief, which needs protection, which needs accountability, and which may be moving toward release? Use the five movements.
3. Which parts of what you want depend on the other person? Which faithful steps remain available to you even if they never respond as you hope?
4. Is there something you have been punishing yourself for that God has already forgiven, or that you have never brought to him? If any of this brings up more than you can hold, stop, and defer the session. That is a legitimate decision.

Guided prayer

Use only the lines that fit. Change or omit the others.

Lord, I have received mercy I could never earn. I also carry a real wrong committed against me, and it has caused real harm. ____ did _____. It was wrong. I am not going to pretend it was not. Where I have wanted them to suffer for it, I ask you to take that from me. I keep the boundaries I need. I do not owe them my trust. I will not abandon justice. Do in me what I cannot do in myself. And where I have been paying for my own guilt with suffering, help me to stop. Show me the next faithful step. Amen.

Silence

Suggested length: ten minutes, or the length you can manage. This is deliberately short.

Anchor phrase: "Into your hands I place this wound." Or: "God sees and God cares." Or: "Show me the next faithful step."

Rest in the truth that God is both merciful and just. You do not need to compare the wrong done to you with anything else. Hold only the prayer.

If the silence brings the person's presence too close, if it moves into fear, panic, or reliving rather than remembering, stop, open your eyes, and use the orientation exercise from Lesson 5. That is not failure. It is information that this session needs support, and it can wait.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. What happened in the silence? Write it without interpreting it.
2. Which of the "release is not" statements did you most need to hear? Which have you been confusing with forgiveness, and how has that confusion kept you from it?
3. What safety measure, boundary, report, or consequence will remain in place whatever you release? Write it down. Naming it may make release possible.
4. If you have been punishing yourself, which of the four (conviction, shame, consequence, self-punishment) is actually at work? What would it mean to accept Romans 8:1 as the verdict?

Practical exercise

The default exercise. Write only this, or pray it without writing, and let it be the whole exercise:

God, I place this wound in your care and ask for help with the next faithful step.

That is not a lesser prayer. It is a complete one, and for many readers it is the only honest one available. The next faithful step may be a counsellor, a safety plan, a report, a boundary, or simply rest. God is not waiting for you to forgive before he cares for the wound.

The optional further stage, for readers who are ready and safe. Take an index card and write, in your own words or in this shape:

Today, as far as I am able, I release personal vengeance and place justice in God's hands. This does not surrender safety, truth, restitution, reporting, or lawful accountability. I do not promise what I cannot yet give. If the pain returns, I will not assume this prayer failed; I will ask whether I need lament, support, protection, treatment, or renewed trust. I ask for help with the next faithful step.

Use an initial or no details. Read it to God. Do not send it, do not read it to the person, and do not write anything that would be unsafe for someone else to find. Put it in an envelope, seal it, and write on the front Placed in God's care and today's date. Nothing is destroyed.

If Session Five left you with something to release in yourself, a second card:

God has forgiven _____. I have been responding through _____. Help me distinguish faithful accountability from self-punishment. What repair is mine, I will pursue. What suffering I am using as payment, help me release.

Seal it in the same envelope.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

I am not required to deny the wrong or abandon justice. I release, or ask for help releasing, personal vengeance. I will preserve the boundaries, truth, reporting, and accountability that remain necessary. I place what I cannot control into God's care. God's mercy does not require me to remain in danger.

Day 3: Listen, Renew, and Return

This is what Richmond says in the day's introduction video. Read it before the first session of the day.

Good morning.

This is the final day of your retreat.

Its shape is different from the first two. Day 1 was about arriving. Day 2 was about releasing and telling the truth. Day 3 begins to turn outward again: listening, remembering who you are, and preparing to return.

Much of the deeper work is behind you. If some of it remains unfinished, that is expected and permitted. You were never asked to resolve your whole life in three days.

If you left "Confession and Grace" for this morning, complete it first. Give it the time it needs, rest afterwards, and then return here.

Your first core session today is "Listening for God's Direction."

You will return to Elijah, this time at the entrance of the cave. God speaks in a low whisper and asks him, twice, "What are you doing here?"

You will read the passage slowly and prayerfully. Whatever you sense, write it down without forcing it into a conclusion.

Please hear this clearly: unless immediate safety requires action, nothing you sense today should become an irreversible decision today.

Everything is written down and tested after the retreat—against Scripture read in context, with wise and appropriately qualified people, and with time.

A strong feeling is not automatically an instruction from God.

If an impression tells you to leave something, begin something, make a major commitment, or confront someone, write it on a card marked "To test," and allow it to wait.

Sessions Eight and Nine—"Rediscovering Your Identity" and "Renewing Your Purpose"—are optional. If you have sufficient time and energy, you may choose one of them today.

Do not try to complete both.

If neither is right for today, leave them. The 30-day plan gives you space to complete them at home.

Your final core session, late this afternoon, is "Returning With a New Rhythm."

You will open the envelope you sealed on Day 1. You will then choose four things to carry home: one burden to entrust to God, one responsible action to take, one person to involve, and one sustainable rhythm to keep.

Then you will receive a blessing.

Protect an unhurried hour for this final session. Do not squeeze it between packing and leaving. Pack afterwards, or prepare most of your belongings before the session and leave enough time to finish slowly.

Remember two things.

Silence may feel easier today than it did on Day 1, or it may not. Neither experience determines whether the retreat has been meaningful.

And although the retreat ends today, the work of returning continues. The next thirty days will help you test what you heard, act responsibly, and carry your new rhythm into ordinary life.

Today is not a demand for final answers.

It is the turn toward home.

Set your timer. Open your Bible to 1 Kings 19.

When you are ready, begin.

Listening for God's Direction

Day 3, morning (or after Session Five, if you did that this morning; take a proper break between them)

Before you begin

Good morning. This is the last day, and its shape is different from the first two. Day 1 was about arriving. Day 2 was about releasing and telling the truth. Day 3 turns outward again: listening, remembering who you are, and preparing to return. The heavier work is behind you, and if some of it is unfinished, that is expected and permitted.

This session is about listening. Before you start, reread the paragraph in Lesson 5 called "A word about hearing from God," because everything in this session depends on it. Whatever you sense today will be written down and tested. Unless immediate safety requires action, no major, irreversible, or high-risk decision is made during a retreat.

Central passage

1 Kings 19:9–18

Read it twice. The second time, notice that God's response includes both correction and provision.

Teaching

We have been following Elijah since Lesson 1, and this is where his story arrives. Strengthened by the food God provided, Elijah travelled forty days and nights until he reached Horeb, the mountain closely associated with Moses and Israel's covenant history, and he entered a cave. God's first words to him are a question: "What are you doing here, Elijah?"

Elijah's answer reflects both genuine danger and a perception narrowed by isolation: he believes he is the only faithful one left, and that they seek his life. Then God tells him to stand on the mountain, and there is a wind that tears rocks apart, and an earthquake, and a fire, and the text says three times that the LORD was not in them. After the fire comes something the Hebrew describes with a phrase that is difficult to reproduce exactly; translations range from "a still small voice" and "a gentle whisper" to "a sound of sheer silence." Elijah hears it, covers his face, and goes to the mouth of the cave. And God asks the same question again: "What are you doing here, Elijah?"

Elijah gives the same answer, word for word. And then God speaks, and this is the part to notice. He does not give Elijah a full explanation or remove every threat. He gives direction involving two future kings and Elisha, Elijah's prophetic successor. He corrects the complaint: there are seven thousand in Israel who have not bowed to Baal; Elijah is not alone. And he sends him back the way he came. God's earlier care, the food and the sleep, is now joined by correction, companionship, and direction. Elijah receives work to do, a successor to share it, and the knowledge that the whole thing never depended on him.

I dwell on this because Christians often approach "hearing God" expecting something the passage does not show. We expect explanation, and God gave assignment. We expect to be told we were right, and God gently showed Elijah that his picture was incomplete. And in this particular encounter, the dramatic signs are explicitly distinguished from the form in which the voice comes. The passage does not teach that God always speaks quietly; elsewhere Scripture portrays him speaking through thunder, fire, dreams, prophets, and public events. It teaches us not to equate spectacle with divine direction. Quiet may help us notice what noise obscures, but God is not limited to retreat conditions. Direction may become clearer through Scripture, counsel, ordinary responsibilities, circumstances, or time after the retreat.

One thing the passage does not teach is that correction is authenticated by how uncomfortable it feels. A self-critical person may trust the harshest thought because it feels humbling, and that is a mistake. God's correction is consistent with Scripture, truthful about sin, proportionate, directed toward repentance and life, and distinct from

vague condemnation or self-hatred. Conviction identifies something that can be confessed or changed. Condemnation declares the whole person hopeless. If what you sense today sounds like the second, it is not the voice you are listening for.

Now, how does God speak? Christians commonly seek his guidance through Scripture, prayer, conscience, wise counsel, and careful attention to circumstances. Only Scripture functions as the church's authoritative written standard. 2 Timothy 3:16–17 says all Scripture is God-breathed and useful for teaching, reproof, correction, and training, so that God's people may be "complete, equipped for every good work." Most of what God has to say to you about how to live is already written, and a great deal of "seeking direction" is simply the search for something more exciting than obedience to what we already know. Before you listen for anything new, ask what Scripture already says about the matter in front of you.

Every personal interpretation, impression, circumstance, and piece of counsel remains fallible and must be tested. The Holy Spirit may bring conviction, but not every feeling of guilt comes from the Spirit; conscience itself needs formation through Scripture, truth, community, and, where relevant, mental-health care. And even a genuine call may need another person to recognise it. Samuel, in 1 Samuel 3:1–10, heard God's voice three times and each time ran to Eli, assuming the old priest was calling. Eli was an imperfect man; the same book records his failures with his sons. Yet in that moment he gave Samuel a wise response, and told the boy what to say: "Speak, LORD, for your servant hears." Even in a time when the word of the Lord was rare, Samuel needed another person to help him interpret what was happening. You are not meant to do this alone. The retreat's insistence on a support person and on Module 5's testing is not a lack of faith in God's voice. It is Eli.

Here are the tests, which Lesson 5 introduced and Module 5 will apply in detail.

- Does it agree with Scripture, read in context?
- Does it reflect the character and fruit of Christ?
- Is it truthful about facts, not merely feelings?
- Does it withstand time and careful questioning?
- What do mature and appropriately qualified advisers say?
- Does it respect safety, consent, justice, and accountability?
- Does it require secrecy, superiority, recklessness, or immunity from challenge?
- Is the proposed action proportionate and reversible?
- Are you sufficiently rested, regulated, informed, and supported to decide?

Two things the tests are not. Urgency is a reason to slow down, unless immediate safety or a genuine external deadline requires action. And peace may accompany discernment, but it is not proof; people can feel peaceful about harmful decisions, and faithful action can feel frightening.

On responsibilities: does what you sense deal faithfully with legitimate responsibilities rather than using spiritual language to escape them? And does it also recognise that some roles, expectations, or relationships may need to change for reasons of truth, safety, justice, or health? Both questions are real, and Module 5 will help you hold them together.

Two further cautions. First, if you hear a voice that others cannot hear, particularly one that issues commands, threatens you, or makes it hard to tell internal experience from external reality, do not assume it is God. End the retreat and seek prompt professional assessment. If a voice commands you to harm yourself or someone else, tells you that you have a unique world-saving mission, or makes you feel unable to remain safe, seek urgent professional or emergency help and do not remain alone. Second, if you listen and sense nothing at all, you have not failed. Lesson 12 said this. Faithful listening that hears nothing is still faithful, and God's direction may come later, through ordinary means, when you are back in ordinary life.

Self-assessment

In your journal:

1. God asked Elijah, "What are you doing here?" Answer it for yourself, honestly, in a few sentences. Not why you came, but what you are actually doing here, now, on the third morning.
2. In the past, what have you understood as God's guidance? Looking back, what fruit, correction, confirmation, or later evidence helped you evaluate it?
3. Is there a decision, a direction, or a question you have been hoping this retreat would settle? Write it in one line.
4. What does Scripture already say about that matter, as far as you know? If you are not sure, write that down; it is the first thing to find out.

Guided prayer

Use only the lines that fit. Change or omit the others.

Speak, Lord, for your servant hears. Here is what I am doing here: _____. I am not asking only for comfort, or for permission. I am asking for your direction, even where it corrects me. Show me what your Word already says. Give me the people I need to recognise your voice. Whatever I sense today, I will write down and test, and I will not act rashly. If I hear nothing, I will trust you anyway. Amen.

Silence

Suggested length: twenty minutes. This is the longest silence in the retreat. Adjust it to what you can manage; ten is a complete practice, and so is five.

Anchor phrase: "Speak, Lord, for your servant hears." Or, shorter: "Here I am."

This is a period of prayerful attention, not a message-detection exercise. Bring your one-line question before God, release the demand for an answer, and remain with the phrase. Do not chase an answer. A thought's vividness, repetition, emotional force, or sudden appearance does not make it divine; unwanted thoughts and images should not be treated as instructions or revelations. If something seems significant, write one or two neutral words on a card and return to the anchor. Recording it does not endorse it. If nothing comes, stay with the phrase. Attention is the practice; the outcome is not yours to produce.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. Write down, without editing, anything you sensed during the silence: a verse, a thought, a phrase, a picture, a direction, or nothing. Do not decide yet whether it was God.
2. Did anything seem corrective, encouraging, clarifying, or unresolved? Do not force one of these categories if nothing significant emerged.
3. For anything significant, go through the tests above and mark each one "supports," "raises concern," "not yet examined," or "requires qualified advice." Nothing is confirmed until those checks are complete, and several of them cannot be completed on a retreat.
4. Who is a mature, trustworthy Christian who knows Scripture, understands your situation, respects appropriate boundaries, and has no interest in controlling your decision? For medical, legal, financial, or abuse-related matters, who has the relevant competence? If you do not have such people, who could you begin to ask?

Practical exercise: listening with Scripture

This exercise uses a longstanding Christian practice: slow, prayerful attention to Scripture. It takes twenty to thirty minutes.

Choose a passage. If Scripture addresses your matter directly, study a substantial passage in context rather than searching for an isolated confirming verse; for complex decisions, note the broader biblical principles involved and seek informed guidance after the retreat. If your question is not one Scripture speaks to directly, choose one of these: Psalm 25:4–10, Proverbs 3:5–8, or James 1:5–8. Each is about seeking God's way.

Read the passage slowly, three times, with a pause between each reading.

After the first reading, notice which word or phrase stands out to you. Do not analyse why. Write it down.

After the second reading, ask what that word or phrase is saying in its own context, to its original hearers. Read the verses around it. If you do not know the historical or literary context, write "I need to study this" rather than guessing, and use a reliable study Bible or commentary after the retreat. Write a sentence.

After the third reading, ask what it might be saying to you, in your situation, in light of your question. Write that down too, and mark it clearly as what I sense, not what God said.

Then take an index card and write two things on it: What I sense: followed by your sentence, and What I will test it against: followed by the tests, and the names of the people you will consult. Keep this card with the Act, Share, and Seek-counsel cards from Session Three. It goes home with you. Module 5's first lesson is built around it.

Do not make a major, irreversible, high-risk, or life-altering decision solely on the basis of today's impression. Low-risk actions already supported by Scripture and wisdom, such as arranging counsel, making a medical appointment, or gathering information, may be appropriate. Waiting is not unbelief. It acknowledges that our interpretation is fallible even when God is faithful. If an impression conflicts with Scripture, promotes harm, or cannot withstand truthful examination, do not treat it as divine direction. If it remains unclear, leave it unclear rather than forcing certainty.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

God has spoken authoritatively in Scripture, and I will begin there. I have brought my question honestly without demanding an immediate answer. Any impression I recorded remains an impression until it has been tested. I will seek wise and appropriately qualified counsel. I will not use God's name to justify harm, haste, secrecy, or escape. If faithful responsibility calls me back, I will respond with wisdom, safety, and support.

Rediscovering Your Identity

Flex session: Day 3 afternoon if there is capacity, otherwise in the 30-day plan

Before you begin

This is a flex session. If you have come to it on Day 3 with energy to spare, welcome. If you are reading it three weeks later at your kitchen table, also welcome; it was written with both of you in mind. Nothing here depends on the retreat setting except a little quiet.

It is gentler than the Day 2 sessions. Its subject is who you are when the roles are set aside for a moment, and for many burned-out people that question is uncomfortable not because it is painful but because they have never had time to ask it.

Central passage

Matthew 3:13–17, followed by Matthew 4:1–11

Read both passages once, in sequence. Then read 3:17 again on its own.

Teaching

Before Jesus began his public ministry, before the recorded sermons, healings, miracles, and calling of disciples, he was baptised in the Jordan, and a voice from heaven said, "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased."

Notice the timing. The declaration comes before the public work. Jesus had already lived many years of faithful human life; Luke 2 shows him growing, worshipping, and living obediently within his family. But he did not earn or acquire his sonship through public performance. The baptismal declaration identifies who he already is. His later obedience expresses that identity; it does not manufacture it.

Then notice what happens immediately afterwards. Matthew 4 opens with Jesus led into the wilderness, and twice the tempter begins, "If you are the Son of God..." The temptations invite Jesus to use sonship on the tempter's terms: satisfy hunger through power, stage a spectacle, demand that God prove his protection, and finally take the kingdoms by bowing to someone other than the Father. The implication is: if you are the Son of God, prove it on these terms. Jesus refuses to turn identity into self-serving performance, answers from Scripture, and remains obedient. The sonship was never in question, and he does not need to demonstrate it.

I begin here because burnout may expose how closely a person's worth has become attached to usefulness, achievement, or being needed. That does not mean identity caused the burnout; Lesson 4 was clear that burnout has structural causes, and this session does not replace that. It means exhaustion can reveal a dependence that was harder to notice while the role was going well. As long as the doing continues, the sense of self holds. When the doing falters, through exhaustion, illness, redundancy, a child leaving home, retirement, or the end of a ministry, the question "who am I if I am not doing this?" arrives, and it can be frightening, because there may be no answer ready.

The baptismal declaration belongs uniquely to Jesus, the eternal and beloved Son. Christians do not become children of God in precisely the same way he is the Son. Yet through union with Christ and the Spirit of adoption, those who belong to him are truly welcomed into God's family. 1 John 3:1: "See what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God; and so we are." Not "so we will be, once we have done enough." So we are. Galatians 4:6–7 adds: "because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, 'Abba! Father!'" So you are no longer a slave, but a son, and if a son, then an heir through God." Paul's immediate contrast concerns slavery under the law and adoption as heirs through Christ, and his legal adoption imagery includes women and men alike as heirs. The image nevertheless challenges performance-based belonging: the believer's place in God's family is received through Christ, not earned through usefulness. The Spirit in the believer

cries "Father," which is a cry of belonging, not of performance.

This does not mean roles are unimportant, or that you should feel nothing when one ends. You are a parent, or a pastor, or a nurse, or a provider, and those are real callings with real weight, and losing one is a real loss that Session Four gave you room to grieve. A deeper identity in Christ can provide a foundation when a role changes or ends. It does not eliminate grief or disorientation, and spiritually mature people still experience both. But it reminds the person that the role was never the whole of who they were. Without that foundation, a person may experience the end of a role as though the self has disappeared with it.

A caution. This session is not based on unsupported positive thinking or the idea that repeating flattering statements can create reality. It is grounded in what Scripture says about belonging to Christ, which is true whether or not you feel it. Psychological care and healthy self-regard are not competitors with that truth. And if worthlessness is persistent, affects many areas of life, interferes with daily functioning, or accompanies hopelessness, loss of interest, major changes in sleep or appetite, or thoughts of death, seek professional care. You do not need to wait until it becomes severe. Lesson 5 applies.

Self-assessment

In your journal:

1. List the roles you hold: family, work, church, community. All of them, including the informal ones, like "the one who holds everyone together." This is not asking you to erase your relational or vocational identity; "parent," "pastor," "friend," and "neighbour" describe real relationships and responsibilities. The question is whether any one role has become the sole measure of your worth.
2. Beside each, mark honestly how much of your sense of worth rests on it. A little, some, or a great deal.
3. Which role, if it ended tomorrow, would leave you least sure who you are?
4. If you could not mention achievements, productivity, income, influence, or how useful you are to others, what would you want someone to understand about you? Try to write two sentences.

Guided prayer

Use only the lines that fit. Change or omit the others.

Father, before Jesus began his public ministry, you declared him to be your beloved Son. Through him, you have adopted me and called me your child. I have sometimes measured my worth by usefulness, approval, and achievement, and it has made me tired, because I never get to stop.

Help me recognise what is true without denying the importance of my callings. Let my roles grow from belonging rather than becoming the price of belonging. Teach me to serve without making service the measure of whether I am loved. Amen.

Silence

Suggested length: fifteen minutes, or the length you can manage.

Anchor phrase: "See what love the Father has given us." Or: "Abba, Father." If parental language is difficult for you because of your own history, use instead: "Nothing can separate me from the love of God in Christ."

In this silence, you are not producing, solving, or proving anything. You may sit, stand, walk slowly, or use gentle movement while remaining with the passage. Each time your mind reaches for a task, a role, or a reason to be useful, notice it, and return to the phrase. If the phrase feels inaccessible, do not force yourself to claim an emotional certainty you do not have. Read the verse as Scripture, "You call your people children of God," or pray, "Help me understand what adoption in Christ means for me." If it triggers severe distress, pause the session, and bring what happened to someone you trust.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. What happened when you tried to be rather than do in the silence? Restlessness, relief, discomfort, blankness? Write it down.
2. The tempter's challenge carried the implication, "Prove who you are on these terms." Where have you been trying to prove your worth through achievement, usefulness, visibility, or sacrifice?
3. Which role could you hold with less fear or compulsion if you trusted that it was not the source of your worth? Is there any optional responsibility that may need to be reduced, delegated, or released?
4. Is there a loss of role, past or approaching, that you have been treating as a loss of self? Name it.

Practical exercise: what I do, what matters, what remains

Take a page in your journal and make three columns.

What I do	What matters about this role	What remains true beyond this role
Pastor	Teaching and caring for people	I remain God's child and part of Christ's body when I am not preaching
Parent	Loving and protecting my children	My worth is not measured by my children's choices
Provider	Supporting my household	Income and usefulness are not the price of God's love

Fill in your own roles. The first column you already know. The second column honours what the role genuinely is; do not skip it.

The third column is the work of the exercise: for each role, what remains true of you, in Christ, if the role changed or ended?

To fill the third column, draw on what Scripture says is true of those who belong to Christ, in your own words, with the references. Do not invent these; find them. Some to start from:

- Created in God's image (Genesis 1:27)
- A child of God (1 John 3:1)
- Loved by God while still a sinner; his love was not earned by my improvement (Romans 5:8)
- Not condemned (Romans 8:1)
- Adopted, not enslaved (Galatians 4:7)
- Chosen in Christ for holiness (Ephesians 1:4)
- A recipient of grace, not self-made (Ephesians 2:8–10)
- Part of Christ's body, with gifts and limits (1 Corinthians 12:12–27)
- Called to love God and neighbour (Matthew 22:37–39)
- A work in progress under God's care (Philippians 1:6)
- Not separated from God's love by anything (Romans 8:38–39)
- Not left or forsaken by God (Hebrews 13:5)

When the page is done, look at it whole. Then, on an index card, copy the three or four lines from the third column that you most needed to read. Read the card aloud, if you have privacy, as a statement of what is true rather than what you feel. Keep it. This card goes home with you too, and it belongs somewhere you will see it on the day a role ends, or a task fails, or someone stops needing you. Keep it where it is both useful and private; if displaying Christian material or personal writing could create conflict or danger, store it securely or use a neutral phrase.

If the third column felt inaccessible, identify why: emotional numbness, theological uncertainty, painful experiences with parental language, doubt about belonging to Christ, or simply unfamiliarity. Do not force

certainty. Bring the page to a mature and safe Christian guide who will listen rather than pressure you. Some truths need to be spoken by someone else before they can be received.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

Before Jesus began his work, the Father called him beloved; through him, I am called God's child. What I do rests on who I am, not the other way round. My roles matter, and they are not the measure of my worth. I am not a slave who must stay useful. I am a child who is loved.

Renewing Your Purpose

Flex session: Day 3 afternoon if there is capacity, otherwise in the 30-day plan

Before you begin

This is the second flex session, and it builds on Session Eight. If you have not done Eight, you can still do this one, but the two belong together: identity first, then purpose. If you are on Day 3, check honestly whether you have the energy for this before Session Ten. If not, it will keep.

A word about what this session is not. It is not a career-change session, a call to a grand mission, or a place to decide whether to leave your job or your ministry. Session Seven's rule stands: no major, irreversible, or high-risk decision is made on a retreat. This session is about something quieter and more durable: where purpose comes from, and how to renew it, or narrow it, when it has drained away into obligation.

Central passage

John 21:15–19

Read it twice. The second time, count the questions and notice what Jesus does not ask.

Teaching

Peter had denied Jesus three times on the night of the arrest. After the resurrection, on a beach in Galilee, after breakfast, Jesus addresses him directly and asks three times: "Simon, son of John, do you love me?" The three questions naturally recall Peter's three denials, suggesting a deliberate and painful restoration. Peter had already wept over his denial, and the third question now grieves him deeply. He says, "Lord, you know everything; you know that I love you." And each time, Jesus gives him something to do: "Feed my lambs. Tend my sheep. Feed my sheep."

Notice what Jesus does not ask. He does not ask, "Will you try harder?" He does not ask for a five-year plan. He moves beyond bare remorse toward love, responsibility, and renewed following. In this passage, renewed purpose is rooted in relationship with Christ and expressed through loving service. The work does not purchase the relationship; it becomes an expression of it. Love here is not merely an emotion underneath the task; it is the orientation that shapes how the task is carried. And the purpose is given to someone who had just failed, publicly and badly, which means the giving of purpose is not a reward for success.

One safeguard belongs here, because Session Five dealt with serious harm. Peter's restoration does not establish that every person who commits serious misconduct should return to leadership. Forgiveness, fellowship, and usefulness in God's kingdom are not identical to reinstatement in a particular office. Abuse, exploitation, criminal conduct, or serious breaches of trust may permanently disqualify someone from certain roles even where repentance is genuine.

Look also at what the purpose is. "Feed my sheep." It is not a strategy or a title. It is care for people who belong to Jesus. When the New Testament describes what God's people are for, it consistently comes back to something like this. Jesus, asked for the greatest commandment, gave two: love God with everything, and love your neighbour as yourself (Matthew 22:37–39). Micah 6:8 says the Lord requires that we "do justice, and love kindness, and walk humbly with your God." Ephesians 2:10 says believers are "created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them." None of these requires a grand platform. They can begin with a small, proportionate act of faithfulness, sometimes including rest, receiving help, or allowing someone else to carry the work.

I labour this because burnout can change a person's relationship to purpose. Work once experienced as meaningful may become mechanical, compulsory, or emotionally distant. Ministry becomes programmes. Parenting becomes

logistics. Care becomes caseload. The experience of love may become harder to feel beneath exhaustion, repetition, conflict, and excessive demands. That does not prove that love has disappeared. Work separated from relationship, meaning, support, and healthy limits can become unbearable weight. But at times faithful duty continues when warm feeling is absent, and that perseverance can itself be an expression of love. If you have been caring for people while feeling nothing, you have not stopped loving them. You may have run out of what love needs to be felt.

Renewing purpose, then, may involve recovering meaning within existing work. It may also involve narrowing the role, sharing it, changing how it is structured, or eventually leaving it after careful discernment. Renewed love cannot make an unsafe or unsustainable structure healthy by itself. Session Seven raised the possibility that some roles need to change for reasons of truth, safety, justice, or health, and Session Three gave you cards for shared and delegated burdens. Purpose renewed is sometimes purpose narrowed. Peter was told to feed sheep, not to run the world.

Purpose often begins close to home: in loving God, receiving grace, caring for neighbours, practising justice and kindness, using what you have faithfully, and accepting appropriate care yourself. It may include people already within your responsibilities, but it is not limited to being needed by others. Some readers have few dependants, or are between roles, or are recovering from illness, and their purpose in this season may consist largely in receiving. Elijah was fed before he was sent.

A caution about the metaphor. Peter was specifically commissioned to shepherd Christ's people. Most readers should not label others "my sheep"; the phrase can sound possessive, and the specific assignment does not transfer. Ask instead: who currently falls within my legitimate sphere of love, neighbourliness, service, or responsibility? For pastors, "the flock entrusted to your care" may be the right phrase. For everyone else, the principle holds without the label.

One more thing from the passage. It ends with Jesus telling Peter that he will one day be led where he does not want to go, and then two words: "Follow me." Peter's purpose remains inseparable from following Christ. The task is not an independent project; its shape must continue to be tested against the person and way of Jesus. That is true for you as well.

Self-assessment

In your journal:

1. Did your main role once feel meaningful or life-giving? If so, what mattered about it then? If it never did, what originally led you into it?
2. Where has care become emotionally depleted or mechanically performed? Be specific: which tasks, which relationships, which parts of the role.
3. Who is presently within your legitimate sphere of care or responsibility? Who is not?
4. Honestly: if Jesus asked you "Do you love me?" today, what would you say? Write the true answer, including "I am not sure" if that is it. Do not turn this into a test of whether your feelings are intense or pure enough. In Scripture, love includes allegiance, trust, obedience, desire, and return, not uninterrupted emotional warmth.

Guided prayer

Use only the lines that fit. Change or omit the others.

Lord, you know everything. You know what I have loved and how tired I am. You asked Peter whether he loved you, and then you gave him work. Ask me. _____. That is my answer, as honestly as I can give it. Help me recognise the responsibilities and relationships that are legitimately mine in this season, and the ones I have assumed through fear, pressure, or the need to be indispensable. Renew love where it has become obscured, and show me where I need rest, support, structural change, grief, or a different form of service. Where something must narrow or end, show me, and I will test it. Keep me following you into whatever comes. Amen.

Silence

Suggested length: fifteen minutes, or the length you can manage.

Anchor phrase: "Lord, you know everything." Or, if it is honest today: "Lord, you know that I love you."

In this silence, sit with the question Jesus asked Peter. Do not answer it in words; you already did in the journal. Simply let it be asked once, and notice what rises: warmth, resistance, grief, longing, nothing. Whatever comes is information, not a verdict. If religious self-checking is compulsive for you, do not repeat the question during the silence; stay with the first anchor phrase instead.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. What rose in the silence when the question was asked?
2. Is there a failure that you have treated as proof that grace, growth, or faithful participation are no longer possible? Write it down, and write what this passage says to it. Then, honestly: what restoration may be possible, and what roles may still remain inappropriate or require accountability?
3. Of the people within your care, where has care become depleted? What support, boundary, rest, or small act of attention might help you care more humanely this week?
4. Is any responsibility being sustained mainly by fear, approval-seeking, or the need to prove yourself? What other legitimate reasons remain? Most motives are mixed; mark it for discernment rather than judging it from motive alone.

Practical exercise: a purpose for this season

You are not going to write a mission statement. You are going to answer four questions and then write one sentence, for one season, that fits on an index card.

First, the four questions, briefly, in your journal:

1. Who or what is genuinely within my care?
2. What is outside my responsibility?
3. What does love look like within my present capacity?
4. What support or boundary will make this sustainable? Then the sentence, in this shape or one like it:

In this season, I want to practise love of God and neighbour by ____, within the limits and responsibilities I currently have.

The blank is specific and small. Not "changing the world." Not "reaching my potential." Something like: "by being present with my children in the evenings instead of half-present," or "by preaching to the congregation I have rather than the one I wish I had," or "by caring well for my mother while she is still here," or "by doing my work honestly and going home on time." And for readers whose season is one of receiving: "by attending treatment and allowing others to support me," "by resting while my body heals," "by doing one responsibility faithfully rather than carrying five," or "by being present to God without needing to produce." If you cannot fill the blank with something small, you have not narrowed it enough.

Underneath, write one line beginning One faithful thing: and name a single action, doable in the next month, that expresses the sentence. Not a plan. One thing. It should be safe, proportionate, within your control, and compatible with your current capacity. Rest, asking for help, making an appointment, or declining a non-essential responsibility can count.

Read the card to God. Keep it with the Act, Share, and Seek-counsel cards from Session Three and the identity card from Session Eight. Module 5's 30-day plan will ask you to look at it again on Day 30 and see whether the sentence still fits.

If the exercise surfaced something larger, a sense that a role should end, or change, or that something you have been carrying is not yours, write it on a separate card marked To test, and put it with the Session Seven card. It is not a decision. It is a question for the testing that Module 5 will walk you through, with the people who can help you weigh it.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

My purpose begins in relationship with Christ, not in proving my worth. I will practise love within the responsibilities and limits of this season. What has become unsustainable, I will bring into honest discernment. I do not have to change the world. I can take one faithful step.

Returning With a New Rhythm

Before you begin

This is the last session, and it should be done settled, not rushed. If you have come to it straight from Session Seven, or from Eight or Nine, make sure you have eaten and rested first. Set aside at least an unhurried hour, with flexibility for more time or a short break. If fatigue rises, divide the session rather than rushing to finish, and leave the evening free afterwards.

Gather the practical and discernment materials from the retreat: your journal; the intention from Lesson 7; your Lesson 1 and Lesson 4 answers; the Act, Share, Entrust, and Seek-counsel cards from Session Three; the "What I sense" card from Session Seven; the identity card from Session Eight and the purpose card from Session Nine, if you did those; and the sealed envelope from Session One, the one marked Not until Day 3. Do not open it yet. Keep the confession, release, and any trauma-related envelopes sealed and secure; this session does not reopen them. Do not display or transport sensitive writing where another person could discover it.

If you deferred sessions, this session is still for you. It does not assume you did all ten. It assumes you came, and stayed, and are now going home.

Central passage

1 Kings 19:19–21, followed by Luke 10:17–20

Read both. In the first, notice what Elijah's return from isolation looks like. In the second, notice what Jesus tells the returning disciples to rejoice in.

Teaching

Elijah's encounter at Horeb ends with the instruction, "Go, return on your way." His wider story continues as he leaves the mountain, and his next recorded action is to find Elisha ploughing in a field and throw his cloak over him. Elisha asks to say goodbye to his parents, then follows. God's response to Elijah's isolation had included food, rest, honest encounter, and the knowledge that seven thousand remained; now it includes Elisha as successor and companion in the work. Elijah returns from isolation to active life knowing he is not the only faithful person left. Isolation begins to give way to shared vocation.

Lesson 2 said that the difference between running away and retreating is that a retreat intends to return. This is the returning. It matters as much as the leaving. Re-entry is where the insights of a retreat meet the pressures of ordinary life, and without support or structural change, old patterns can quickly reassert themselves. An interruption can provide genuine rest and insight; its longer-term influence grows when at least one ordinary pattern changes in response.

So this session is not about resolutions. It is about rhythm. Across the Gospels, Jesus' ministry includes both engagement and withdrawal: teaching, healing, prayer, solitude, meals, travel, and rest. In Mark 6:30–32, the disciples return from their mission, report to him, and he says, "Come away by yourselves to a desolate place and rest a while." Then the crowds find them, the work resumes, and later he withdraws again. This is a pattern of life, not a timetable every reader must reproduce identically. What you take home from these three days is not a peak experience to remember. It is a small, repeatable pattern that lets some of what happened here happen again, in ordinary weeks. Module 5 will help you build it. Today you choose its first piece.

Then there is Luke 10. The larger group of disciples returns from their mission rejoicing: even the demons submit to them. Jesus does not dismiss it, but he redirects it: "do not rejoice in this, that the spirits are subject to you, but rejoice that your names are written in heaven." For those who belong to Christ, the deepest reason for rejoicing is not the quality of a retreat experience but God's saving grace and the belonging Christ gives. Belonging to him is not

earned by a successful retreat or a productive ministry. Service grows from grace; it does not purchase it. If the three days were dry, that belonging is not diminished. If they were rich, that is not what to build on.

Your return may likewise require appropriate companionship: a friend, a spouse, a pastor, a counsellor, a colleague, a recovery community, or professional support. Elijah's return included shared life and shared work. The retreat's insistence on a support person was never only about the three days.

Two things about re-entry, and then the work.

First, expect a dip. Many people feel unusually clear and calm in the last hours of a retreat, and then, sometime in the first days home, flat, irritable, or discouraged. In my pastoral experience this is common, and it does not mean the retreat has worn off. It means the contrast between the quiet and the noise is real, and your body and mind are readjusting. Module 5's first days are designed for this. Do not judge the entire value of the retreat solely by your mood during the first week. However, take severe distress, worsening depression, inability to function, or safety concerns seriously and seek appropriate help.

Second, share selectively and safely. There is a temptation, on the way home, to tell everyone what changed and what you are going to do differently. Some of it will not survive contact with ordinary life, and some of it, as Session Seven said, still needs testing. Tell your designated support person what would help them support you. If you have a safe spouse or partner, explain any practical rhythm that may affect shared life and listen to their concerns. Keep private material private, but bring significant impressions or decisions to appropriately qualified counsel rather than treating secrecy as spirituality. Elijah's next step was not public announcement but embodied obedience and shared work.

Opening the envelope

Now open the envelope from Session One.

Read the cards. These are the ordinary demands you set down on the first morning. Some will feel exactly as heavy as they did; some, you may notice, feel lighter, or have resolved themselves, or turned out to be smaller than they seemed. Some may have become clearer.

Sort them, using the Session Three marks: A for something within your responsibility that needs a next faithful action, S for something to share, E for something to entrust, ? for something needing counsel. Do not assume every card must return to you as an action. Some may need delegation, counsel, changed expectations, or no action at all. Anything that no longer needs to be done, set aside.

If a card concerns immediate safety, medical care, suicidal thoughts, abuse, safeguarding, or a genuine crisis, do not place it into the ordinary thirty-day plan. Seek the appropriate help promptly.

You are picking these up again. But you are picking them up after three days of practising how to carry things, and you may find that you hold them differently.

Self-assessment

In your journal:

1. Reread the three questions you answered at the end of Lesson 1, and your answers. Then reread your intention from Lesson 7, all four parts. Without forcing it: what has shifted, what has become clearer, and what may still need attention, support, prayer, or discernment after you return? Write honestly, including "nothing yet" if that is true. Lesson 1 told you that you would read these again; this is not a test of whether the retreat worked.
2. Lay out the practical and discernment cards together. What do you notice? Is there a theme, a person who appears more than once, a concern that keeps returning? A repeated theme is worth noticing, but repetition alone does not prove that it is God's central message. It may indicate anxiety, an intrusive concern, an unmet need, or a genuine priority requiring further discernment.
3. Was there a moment, exercise, rest period, conversation, or passage that seems especially important? If nothing stands out yet, write that.

4. What are you afraid will happen when you get home?

Guided prayer

Use only the lines that fit. Change or omit the others.

Lord, you told Elijah to return, and you showed him that he was not alone. I am going back, unfinished and still held by your grace. Thank you for what these days contained: _____. What remains unclear, help me carry patiently and test wisely. Give me appropriate companionship, and help me receive it. Go with me into ordinary life, and teach me to recognise your presence there. Give me a rhythm rather than a dramatic resolution. Amen.

Silence

Suggested length: ten minutes, or the length you can manage.

Anchor phrase: "Go, return on your way." Or: "I am not alone."

This is the last silence of the retreat. Spend it not looking back and not planning ahead. Simply be here, one more time, with the God who was here the whole time. The retreat setting will remain behind, but the practice of returning attention to God can travel with you. It may look smaller and less quiet at home, and it can still be real.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

1. What did you notice in the last silence?
2. Of everything that happened, what one thing do you most want to be true in a month's time? Write it as a sentence beginning "In a month, I hope..."
3. Who will you tell about the retreat, and what will you tell them? Who will you not tell yet, and why?
4. What is the next deliberate pause or form of support you need? It might be a three-hour reset, a day retreat, a counselling appointment, a Sabbath practice, or a protected hour. Write it down. A rhythm needs a next time.

Practical exercise: four things to take home

Older Christian traditions sometimes use the phrase "rule of life" for a realistic pattern of prayer, rest, work, worship, and relationship. "Rule" here means a supportive framework, not a system for earning God's approval. Module 5 will help you build one. Today you take home four things, each on one card.

One thing to entrust. From the Entrust cards, or the envelope, choose the single matter you most need to stop trying to control. Write it on a card with the words "placed in God's care."

One action to take. From the Act cards, the purpose card, or the envelope, choose one next faithful step, doable in the first two weeks home. Small, specific, within your control.

One person or source of support. Name the person, or the service, you will contact in the first week. Your support person, your Eli, a counsellor, a doctor, a recovery community. Write when you will contact them.

One sustainable rhythm. Choose one piece of a rule of life and commit to it for thirty days. Choose something small enough for a difficult ordinary week; in a crisis, illness, or emergency, the rhythm may need to pause without guilt. Choose a rhythm compatible with your health, household, work, caregiving responsibilities, and safety. Options, all adaptable:

- A daily quiet. Up to ten minutes, at a roughly fixed time, with a psalm and a short silence. The Lesson 8 practice, continued.
- A weekly hour. One protected hour each week, phone away, alone with God; shorter blocks count if an hour is impossible.
- A digital boundary. One element of Lesson 9 kept permanently, with emergency access preserved.

- A protected period of ceasing. A day, or half a day, each week without your ordinary work, adapted for caregivers, shift workers, and medical needs. Module 5 gives Sabbath the fuller treatment it deserves; for these thirty days, simply protect the time.
- A conversation. A regular meeting with a trustworthy and competent person in which you say honestly how you are.
- A rest that is yours. A named thing that restores you, protected weekly without guilt; recreation, not compulsive escape. Write the rhythm on a card, with the day, the time, and the place, as concretely as you can. Write underneath what you will do when you miss it, because you will: "When I miss it, I will start again the next day without guilt." Read the four cards to God.

Then sort every card from the retreat into two groups. Action cards: the four you have just written, plus any Act, Share, and Seek-counsel cards that are safe, practical reminders. Carry these in an accessible place; Module 5's 30-day plan begins with them on Day 1. Private cards: anything sensitive, identifying, traumatic, or spiritually intimate, including the sealed envelopes. Seal or securely store these. If your belongings may be searched or monitored, do not carry written material that could place you at risk.

If you deferred sessions, write on a card "Optional sessions to revisit" and include only those you genuinely want to reconsider. Deferral may be the final wise decision, not incomplete work. The 30-day plan has a place for them if you want it.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

I came as honestly as I could, and grace met me here. I am returning with some clarity and some unfinished questions. I will not carry ordinary life alone. I take one small rhythm and one next faithful step. My retreat experience is not the measure of God's faithfulness. (Optional:) My name is written in heaven, and that is what I will rejoice in.

A blessing

These words were given to Israel's priests as a blessing over the people (Numbers 6:24–26), and they have been spoken over God's people for millennia. Receive them now as Scripture's ancient words of blessing, aloud if you can.

The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace.